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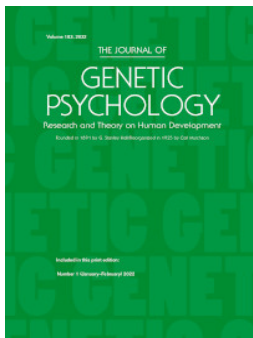


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Similarities and Differences in Popular Peers in Adolescence and Emerging Adulthood

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ABSTRACT

The transition to emerging adulthood is accompanied by shifts in social ecology that influence the attributes that garner popularity among peers. The goal of this study was to compare descriptions of popular high school and college peers. Participants were 218 college undergraduates (70% female, mean age 19.6 years) at a large, public Midwestern university. Participants provided descriptions of their popular male and female college peers, and retrospective descriptions of their popular male and female high school peers. Descriptions were coded into one of 11 content categories and rated for their valence. Popular high school students were described in terms of their appearance, wealth, and athletic ability. Popular college students were described in terms of their prosocial behavior, peer interactions, social competencies, and involvement in campus groups. Emerging adulthood may bring a shift in the meaning of popularity toward more prosocial attributes and behaviors that facilitate the development of positive relationships with others.

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Popularity is a measure of social prestige, visibility, and influence within peer groups (Cillessen et al., 2011). Distinct from social preference, or likeability and acceptance by peers, popularity typically refers to adolescents who are 'cool' and enjoy a high-status position among peers (Rodkin et al., 2006). Though not universal, the desire to be popular is a priority for some adolescents, with many endorsing popularity as an explicit social goal (e.g. Dawes & Xie, 2014). Furthermore, the desire for popularity does not necessarily end with adolescence. A sizeable proportion of college students has been shown to prioritize popularity over friendship, romantic, and rule-adherence goals (LaFontana & Cillessen, 2010). The literature on self-determination theory (Deci & Ryan, 2000) further supports the notion that some adults value and pursue extrinsic goals, including social recognition and admiration (e.g. Kasser & Ryan, 1996). As reviewed below, researchers have extensively studied the correlates of popularity in child and adolescent samples, while our understanding of popularity in emerging adulthood remains limited. Thus, the overarching goal of the current investigation was to expand our understanding of peer popularity in emerging adulthood, highlighting differences between adolescent and young adult popular peers that might reflect changes in the social ecology in which popularity functions.

An important component of the current study is its use of an open-ended approach to elicit information from participants about the attributes associated with popularity. Unlike most studies of peer status that have relied on a combination of peer nominations, peer- or teacher ratings, and self-report surveys, we asked open-ended questions about what made peers popular and allowed participants to generate as many descriptors as they wished. Though less common, this

approach has been used successfully in prior studies with children and adolescents. For example, LaFontana and Cillessen (2002) elicited descriptions of popular and unpopular peers from fourth- through eighth-graders and found distinct patterns; for example, popular peers were described as being highly sociable and well-integrated into the peer group. Xie and colleagues used a similar approach to elicit descriptions of popular and unpopular peers from first- through seventh-graders and detected important developmental differences (Xie et al., 2006). Closson (2009) employed a similar open-ended method with adolescents, asking participants to provide up to six words that describe what it means to be popular, while also exploring the roles of participant gender and popularity in the descriptions they provided. Thus, prior research eliciting open-ended descriptions of popular peers has contributed to our understanding of prominent peer status in important ways. The current study aims to build on this qualitative literature (see also de Bruyn & Cillessen, 2006).

Developmental changes in popularity

Researchers have consistently found positive associations between popularity and other indicators of social prestige, such as dominance and resource control (Hawley et al., 2008; LaFontana & Cillessen, 2002; Lease et al., 2002) and admiration and leadership (Lease et al., 2002; Puckett et al., 2008), as well as correlations with social competence and self-esteem (de Bruyn & van den Boom, 2005; LaFontana & Cillessen, 2002). Popularity is strongly correlated with physical attractiveness, especially for girls, and with athletic ability in boys (Rose et al., 2011). Popularity is also associated with prosocial behavior such as kindness and trustworthiness (Parkhurst & Hopmeyer, 1998) and having a good sense of humor (Bowker & Etkin, 2014).

Popularity, however, is not always associated with positive behaviors. A growing literature links popularity with aggressive behavior, even bullying (e.g. de Bruyn et al., 2010; Vaillancourt et al., 2003). Evidence from qualitative and quantitative studies suggests that relational aggression (harming or threatening to harm a peer's relationships, acceptance, or reputation) is particularly characteristic of some popular girls (Rose et al., 2011). Furthermore, researchers such as de Bruyn and Cillessen (2006) have found that being popular in early adolescence is associated with other negative descriptions by peers, including being academically disengaged, stuck up, and vulgar. Other researchers have found links between popularity and health-risk-taking behaviors such as smoking, substance use, and risky sexual behavior (Choukas-Bradley et al., 2015; Mayeux et al., 2008; Plumridge et al., 2002).

Because popularity is an index of social prestige, and the attributes that garner social prestige change as children and adolescents grow older, what makes someone popular also changes with age. Xie and colleagues, for example, found a clear developmental pattern in which their fourth- and seventh-grade participants were better able to describe the attributes of popular peers than their first-grade participants, suggesting that popularity is more salient to older children and young adolescents compared to younger children (Xie et al., 2006). This is consistent with evidence that popularity is prioritized more highly by adolescents than it is by children or adults (LaFontana & Cillessen, 2010). Furthermore, first-graders described popular peers as prosocial, while fourth-graders cited physical attractiveness, self-presentation, and good studentship as the most important factors. Seventh-graders' descriptions highlighted attractiveness and self-presentation, but also sports and social connections (Xie et al., 2006). Similarly, in a longitudinal study spanning grades four through six, the importance of attractiveness (for girls) and athletic ability (for boys) in determining self-reported popularity increased over time, while the importance of academic achievement decreased (Chase & Dummer, 1992). These findings are similar to those of ethnographic research, in which certain extracurricular activities were observed to be crucial in establishing popularity in middle school (i.e. cheerleading for girls and sports for boys; Eder & Kinney, 1995).

Other developmental trends in popularity are noteworthy across adolescence. For example, popularity becomes less and less closely tied to social acceptance as adolescents get older.

In childhood, popular peers are described as well-liked in qualitative studies, and popularity is strongly correlated with social acceptance in studies using peer nomination methods (e.g. Troop-Gordon & Ranney, 2014; van den Berg et al., 2015; Xie et al., 2006). However, the correlations decrease steadily across adolescence in longitudinal studies, suggesting that overall peer likeability is no longer a crucial component of popularity at that developmental stage (Cillessen & Borch, 2006; Cillessen & Mayeux, 2004; van den Berg et al., 2015). A recent meta-analysis showed that the positive correlation between acceptance and popularity was significantly stronger in the upper grades of primary school and the lower grades of secondary school (corresponding to ages 9–15) compared to the upper grades of secondary school (roughly age 15–18; van den Berg et al., 2020).

This developmental shift is noteworthy. The social context of popularity changes significantly from the primary grades to secondary school. Most primary school students spend the majority of their school day with the same peers in one classroom. Accordingly, most researchers who measure popularity among primary school children collect peer nominations within classroom. However, as students move into the secondary grades, they typically move through several classes each day, interacting with many more peers and experiencing a much broader social network. As a result, adolescent popularity is usually measured via gradewise, rather than classwise, peer nominations (e.g. Cillessen & Marks, 2011). Notably, the significant shift in the distinction between acceptance and popularity occurs years after the shift in social context. This suggests that it is not the size of the peer group or the changes in social context from primary to secondary school that drive the increasing distinction between acceptance and popularity. Instead, changes in older adolescents' values and goals are likely at the root of what it means to be liked or popular. For example, research suggests that being well-liked by other-sex peers is more important to developing social power in adolescence than is being liked by same-sex peers, highlighting the importance of emerging romantic relationship dynamics (Dijkstra et al., 2010; Houser et al., 2015).

There is far less published research on the attributes associated with popularity beyond adolescence, but a small number of studies of college students provides insight. In a longitudinal study of male fraternity members, Phua (2011) investigated the associations between popularity and health-risk-taking behaviors (i.e. smoking and alcohol use) across the four years of university, using social network analysis. Popularity predicted increases in both smoking and drinking over time. Similarly, a study by Lansu and Cillessen (2012) investigated the correlates of social acceptance and popularity within a college context, using methods similar to those used with adolescents in middle and high schools (i.e. peer nominations). Results mirrored those of some of the adolescent studies, showing popularity to be positively associated with attractiveness, success, relational aggression, respect, and dominant leadership (Lansu & Cillessen, 2012).

Another study of college students utilized student self-reports along with ratings by university Resident Advisors to measure social achievement goals and social adjustment in dorm settings (Shim & Ryan, 2012). Resident Advisors were asked to rate participating residents' popularity, social competence, and adjustment, while participants reported their social achievement goals. Popularity was positively associated with prosocial behavior, social competence, and aggression. Furthermore, popular undergraduates were high in social demonstration goals, endorsing values such as gaining popularity and receiving positive feedback from peers. Popularity was negatively related to anxiety and other internalizing symptoms (Shim & Ryan, 2012). Thus, the few studies of popularity in emerging adulthood suggest patterns that are very similar to those observed in adolescent samples: Popular young adults are seen as attractive, and exhibit a mixed profile of prosocial and aggressive behavior. In at least some social contexts, they show elevated substance use. These studies are noteworthy in that they use diverse methods to explore important correlates of popularity in emerging adults, and yet report findings that are consistent with the large body of research with children and adolescents. However, an important caveat to these studies is that the correlates of peer status measured therein were similar to those explored in the adolescent popularity literature (e.g. substance

use, prosocial and antisocial behavior). While this is helpful in establishing that at least some status-based patterns show continuity across the transition to young adulthood, it leaves room to identify additional correlates that emerge as important for establishing social power as adolescents become young adults.

Popularity in the context of emerging adulthood

Peer relationships are not only important contexts of development for children and adolescents; they remain significant influences on social and academic functioning beyond the high school years (Goguen et al., 2010). *Emerging adulthood* is the term used to describe the phase of life between the ages of 18 and 29, and is characterized by changes in social support, vocations, romantic relationships, and worldviews (Arnett, 2000; Erikson, 1968; Rindfuss, 1991). For many emerging adults, this developmental period is accompanied by the transition into college or university life; indeed, approximately 67% of US high school graduates enroll in some form of postsecondary education (National Center for Education Statistics, 2017). For many of these youth, the transition will be reflected in a new living environment, newfound autonomy, novel social and relational opportunities, and changing priorities. An important component of this change is the role of evolving social structures and social norms as adolescents leave high school and enter college. Status dynamics that defined the social hierarchy in high school change once adolescents enter the university context. New social standards have the potential to impact an individual's peer interactions and overall transition into higher education. For example, Scott and Judge (2009) found that the desire for social success does not stop in adolescence but continues well into adulthood, and studies of the prioritization of popularity indicate that popularity remains a salient goal during the college years (LaFontana & Cillessen, 2010). Furthermore, research indicates that making new friends and developing positive peer relationships is important to first-year college success (Friedlander et al., 2007; Paul & Brier, 2001). Thus, college students may have competing social goals related to both popularity and friendship that guide their behavior. This may be especially true at the college transition, as first-year students explore their new social environment and begin to figure out where they fit in.

At the same time, college students' motivations may begin to broaden to include longer-term goals involving academic and relational success. The emerging adulthood years are crucial for the exploration of potential career paths and life options (Arnett, 2000) and they are also a time of significant romantic development, including the emergence of long-lasting relationships (Arnett, 2004). Thus, while popularity and related social goals may dominate in adolescence, they are likely tempered by other important, developmentally appropriate pursuits in emerging adulthood. College students may ascribe popularity to peers who embody the pursuit of these other important life goals, or who are succeeding academically or romantically.

Popularity and gender

Another goal of the current study was to test for gender differences in the attributes associated with popularity in adolescence and emerging adulthood, as well as the role of the gender of the participant (perceiver). The as-yet limited research on popularity in emerging adulthood has yet to indicate significant gender differences, highlighting the need for additional research to explore this area. However, abundant research with adolescents suggests that there are areas of both similarity and discrepancy when it comes to popular boys and girls. Popularity is associated with social connectedness and attractiveness for adolescents of both genders (e.g. Rose et al., 2011). Physical and verbal aggression and bullying are more typical of popular boys than girls (e.g. de Bruyn et al., 2009; Kiefer & Wang, 2016), as are deviance or risk-taking behavior (Xie et al., 2006). Popularity is also tied to athletic ability (e.g. Vaillancourt & Hymel, 2006) and being funny (e.g. Closson, 2009) for adolescent boys, but not girls. Prosocial behavior is more

closely tied to popularity for girls than boys (Puckett et al., 2008), as is relational aggression (e.g. Mayeux & Cillessen, 2008).

Very few studies have explored the role of perceiver gender in adolescent perceptions of popularity, and to our knowledge, no studies have addressed perceiver gender in adult samples. Multiple studies have reported that adolescent girls gave more descriptions of popular peers than did adolescent boys, suggesting that girls may be more attuned to peer group issues (LaFontana & Cillessen, 2002; Xie et al., 2006). In one key study, middle school girls were more likely to provide descriptions related to attractiveness, clothing, meanness, snobbiness, rudeness, and being sociable, compared to boys. In contrast, boys were more likely to describe popular peers in terms of their athleticism, humor, coolness, and risk-taking, compared to girls (Closson, 2009). Popularity in adolescence is more closely tied to how youth are viewed by opposite-sex peers compared to same-sex peers; liking by members of the opposite sex is a stronger predictor of adolescents' popularity than is liking by same-sex peers (Dijkstra et al., 2010). Thus, the available evidence suggests that not only will descriptions of popular peers differ by the gender of the target peer, they may also differ by the gender of the participant/perceiver.

Summary and prospectus

The correlates of popularity have been well-documented in childhood and adolescence, with evidence supporting links between popularity and both positive and negative behavioral and psychological adjustment. However, less is known about popularity in emerging adulthood, a time of significant change and social vulnerability. First-year students are introduced to a new social ecology that brings shifting and competing priorities, and the characteristics associated with popularity may change accordingly. Our primary aim in this investigation was to understand more about how the attributes associated with popularity differ in high school and college. We used an open-ended response methodology (Closson, 2009; LaFontana & Cillessen, 2002) to explore emerging adults' retrospective accounts of their popular peers in high school, and how those accounts differed from their concurrent descriptions of their popular college peers. We were also interested in gender differences in the characteristics attributed to popular peers at both developmental stages, as well as whether the gender of the perceiver influenced the descriptions (Dijkstra et al., 2010).

Though the use of an open-ended approach to data collection did not allow for specific hypotheses regarding the categories of descriptions provided by participants, we did have several hypotheses regarding differences between high school and college, and male and female, popular peers. For example, we anticipated that descriptions of popular college peers would include more references to prosocial behavior, and fewer references to aggressive or antisocial behavior, compared to descriptions of popular high school peers. We also hypothesized that popular college students would be described as more sociable and active in campus organizations than high school students, as being well-integrated into the larger peer group of a university campus would be necessary for the development of visibility and prominence among such a large student body. Finally, we anticipated that descriptions related to being funny, confident, or other positive personality features that increase visibility among peers would be more common for college peers, especially college men, compared to high school students.

This study contributes to the literature on popularity in important ways. First, the open-ended approach allowed us to elicit descriptions of popular high school and college students that were most salient to the participants themselves. Relatedly, participants were asked to describe their popular college peers concurrently, and their popular high school peers retrospectively, in the same study session. By doing so, participants' descriptions were more likely to present a thoughtful account of similarities and differences in popular peers based on their own observations and experiences in those two contexts. Second, this study extends the small literature on popularity in emerging adulthood by more directly comparing perceptions of popular peers in two different, but related, developmental contexts (high school and college). Third, we analyze the descriptions

for gender differences in what makes someone popular, but also for differences in how young men and women perceive their popular peers. Given evidence that an adolescent's level of popularity is strongly determined by how they are viewed by other-sex peers (Dijkstra et al., 2010), understanding the role of the perceiver is an important step in defining what popularity means in young adulthood.

Method

Participants and procedure

Participants were 218 undergraduate students between the ages of 18 and 25 (70% women; mean age = 19.6 years; $SD = 1.54$) enrolled in a large, public university in the Midwest who participated for course credit toward their Introduction to Psychology class. The racial and ethnic diversity of the sample generally reflected that of the broader undergraduate body (5% African-American, 7% Asian, 4% Latinx, 5% Native American, and 77% White; 2% of participants claimed other ethnicities). This study was one of many available to Introduction to Psychology students throughout the spring semester; students were not required to participate, but could choose to participate in the study to satisfy this course requirement. Participants signed up for the study via the Psychology Department's online experiment management software. The faculty researcher was not an instructor in any course section from which participants were recruited.

After providing their written consent, participants responded to a set of surveys and open-ended questions in the lab in one session that took less than an hour; the surveys were part of a separate investigation and are not reported here. An undergraduate research assistant was available in the lab for participants who had questions about any of the items. Four questions were posed (Lansu et al., in press): two open-ended questions that asked for descriptions of popular male and female peers in high school (*Think about the girls/guys in your high school class who were popular. In general, what was it about girls/guys like this that made them popular with other kids?*), followed by two questions that asked for descriptions of popular male and female peers in college (*Think about the girls/guys on campus (in your dorm, apartment complex, or classes) who are popular. In general, what is it about girls/guys like this that make them popular with other people?*). Participants were provided with plenty of space to write their responses, and they simply listed words or phrases that were descriptive. These procedures were approved by the University of Oklahoma Institutional Review Board.

Most participants listed multiple descriptions or characteristics for some items, so responses were first separated into distinct descriptions by two independent coders. There was only one discrepancy, which was resolved via discussion, yielding 2,944 total responses across the four questions. These same coders used a subset of the data in conjunction with a review of the extant literature (e.g. Closson, 2009; LaFontana & Cillessen, 2002) to develop an initial coding system that included 39 categories (see the [Appendix](#)).

Three new coders used this system to code each response into one of the 39 categories. As described in LaFontana and Cillessen (2002), responses were assigned to the category that was most specific; for example, if a participant's response was 'how they looked,' it would be categorized as *physical appearance* (Category 1), but if the response referred to a specific element of appearance, such as their attractiveness, it was coded into that subcategory (1a). Cohen's kappa was .61, .66, and .74 for each pair of coders across all categories. All discrepancies were resolved via group discussion and consensus. For ease of analysis, the initial 39 categories were then reduced to 16 by collapsing all subcategory responses back into their parent category. For example, all responses in categories 1, 1a, 1b, and 1c were collapsed into Category 1 (*physical appearance*).

The categories were further reduced to 11 by eliminating two categories that were very rarely used (*(non)conformity*, which was used by only two participants, and *motivation to attain status*, which was used by only one participant), as well as two categories that were too vague to yield

informative findings (*other behaviors* and *other personality features*). In addition, the *academic performance* and *intelligence* categories were combined due to the conceptual similarity of the descriptions in each category and concerns about redundancy. Thus, the final set of categories included *physical appearance*, *material wealth*, *peer interactions*, *risk-taking behavior*, *athletic ability*, *academic ability*, *competencies*, *prosocial behavior*, *dominance*, *school/campus activities*, and *aggressive behavior*.

In addition to categorizing each description, each one was assigned a valence rating that reflected how positive or negative the description was. This was done for two reasons. First, it helped minimize the number of content categories by allowing the assignment of both positive and negative descriptions into certain categories (e.g. *academic ability* was sometimes described in positive terms, such as ‘smart,’ but sometimes in a more derogatory way, such as ‘nerd’). Second, it allowed us to analyze the overall tone of the comments made about popular peers, which was helpful in understanding how popular peers were viewed by others. Accordingly, three additional coders rated the valence of each response on a scale from –4 (most negative) to 0 (neutral) to 4 (most positive). These ratings were averaged across the three coders to create a single valence rating for each response. Interrater reliability (Cronbach’s alpha) based on the ratings of 100% of the responses was .93.

Finally, as described in LaFontana and Cillessen (2002), we combined the content codes and valence ratings into one overall scoring system. The averaged valence ratings for each participant’s responses were added within each of the 11 content categories, for each of the four popular targets separately (male and female high school peers, male and female college peers). For example, if a participant gave two descriptions of female high school peers that were coded as *physical appearance*, and those descriptions had valence ratings of 0 and 4, respectively, those ratings were added to yield a score of 4 for the *physical appearance* category for that target group. Further, scores of ‘0’ were used for categories a participant did not use at all, as their responses did not include a positively- or negatively-valenced comment in that category (reflecting the fact that they did not associate that particular category of attributes with that specific type of peer). This meant that each participant had 44 scores: 11 scores reflecting their descriptions of four targets, male and female high school and college peers. The following analyses thus reflect how often the categories are mentioned for the respective targets, as well as how positive or negative the descriptions in those categories were overall.

Results

Table 1 presents frequencies with which each category of description was used for each type of target. As can be seen in the table, popular high school girls were described largely in terms of their physical appearance, financial wealth, and peer interactions. A closer examination of the subcategories indicated that popular high school girls were often described as attractive

Table 1. Frequencies of category use for descriptions of popular male and female peers.

	HS Females	College Females	HS Males	College Males
Physical Appearance	22.3%	15.7%	17.0%	10.7%
Material Wealth	15.8%	6.9%	12.0%	4.9%
Peer Interactions	20.1%	26.1%	16.4%	25.0%
Risk-Taking Behavior	1.0%	1.3%	1.4%	2.7%
Academic Performance	3.1%	3.3%	2.4%	2.8%
(In)Competencies	7.2%	10.0%	12.3%	16.4%
Prosocial Behavior	7.8%	12.6%	3.8%	9.9%
Dominance	2.0%	2.0%	4.0%	3.5%
School/Campus Groups	9.5%	13.0%	2.7%	11.5%
Aggressive Behavior	1.5%	.003%	1.4%	.003%
Athletic Ability	4.2%	.001%	21.5%	5.9%
Total	94.5%	90.9%	94.9%	93.3%
Number of Descriptions	845	823	649	626

Table 2. Means and standard deviations of valence ratings for descriptions of popular male and female peers.

	High School				College			
	Females		Males		Females		Males	
	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>
Physical Appearance	1.62	1.95	1.42	1.83	.84	1.58	.74	1.44
Material Wealth	.81	1.65	.60	1.46	.28	.84	.23	.87
Peer Interactions	1.17	2.03	1.03	1.68	1.42	2.15	1.43	2.15
Risk Taking	-.12	.56	-.07	.68	-.10	.57	-.12	.69
Athletic Ability	.30	.77	1.49	1.19	.07	.57	.27	.72
Academic Performance	.27	1.01	.11	.88	.26	.89	.18	.77
Competencies/ Incompetencies	.43	1.44	.96	2.97	.60	1.67	1.14	2.32
Prosocial Behavior	.75	1.60	.33	1.23	1.09	2.29	.80	1.66
Dominance	.08	.73	.06	.64	.08	.48	.06	.60
School/Campus Groups	.61	1.20	.18	.69	.53	1.05	.46	.93
Aggressive Behavior	-.17	.90	-.15	.68	-.03	.32	-.00	.28

(15% of participants' descriptions of popular high school girls focused on physical attractiveness). They were also described as having a high socioeconomic status (7.3%), having expensive or desirable possessions (8.2%), and as being outgoing and sociable (8.3%). Descriptions of high school boys focused strongly on athletic ability, physical appearance, and peer interactions. Similar to their popular female peers, high school boys were described as attractive (13.2%), as having desirable possessions (7.5%), and as sociable (7%). They were also more likely than any other group to be described as having a good sense of humor (6%). Popular college women were very frequently described in terms of their sociability and high frequency of peer interactions (15.7%), as well as in terms of their attractiveness (11.4%), prosocial behavior (12.6%), and involvement in campus groups (13.1%). Popular college men were also described in terms of their sociability (15.7%). They were also described in terms of their prosocial behavior (9.9%) and involvement in campus groups (11.5%), and their attractiveness (8.8%).

Table 2 presents the means and standard deviations of the valence scores for each category and for each target. The means represent the overall valence of participants' descriptions of popular peers (i.e. a positive mean score indicates that the overall valence of the descriptions was positive), while the standard deviations indicate the variability in valence of the descriptions provided. Overall, the tone of the descriptions of popular peers was largely positive, with the exception of descriptions of risk-taking and aggressive behavior. However, the large standard deviations for the means in some categories suggest that participants' descriptions of their popular peers varied widely in terms of positive and negative tone.

To address our specific research questions, we investigated the role of perceiver gender, target gender, and target age in descriptions of popular peers by conducting a 2 (participant gender) X 2 (target gender) X 2 (target age) ANOVA on the scores for each of these 11 categories, with target gender and target age as repeated measures factors. Significant effects indicate that participants' descriptions of popular peers varied in terms of their frequency and overall positivity/negativity depending on their own gender, or on the target peers' gender or age. Figures 1 and 2 illustrate the age group differences in descriptions of female and male popular peers, respectively.

Effects of target gender

There were significant effects of target gender for appearance ($F(1, 215) = 4.30, p = .04$, Wilks' $\lambda = .98$, partial $\eta^2 = .02$), athletic ability ($F(1, 215) = 144.42, p = .001$, Wilks' $\lambda = .60$, partial $\eta^2 = .40$), academic ability ($F(1, 215) = 4.31, p = .04$, Wilks' $\lambda = .98$, partial $\eta^2 = .02$), competencies ($F(1, 215) = 17.11, p = .001$, Wilks' $\lambda = .93$, partial $\eta^2 = .07$), prosocial behavior ($F(1, 215) = 4.5, p = .04$, Wilks' $\lambda = .98$, partial $\eta^2 = .02$), and school/campus groups ($F(1, 215) = 28.99, p = .001$, Wilks' $\lambda = .88$, partial $\eta^2 = .12$). Popular male peers were described more

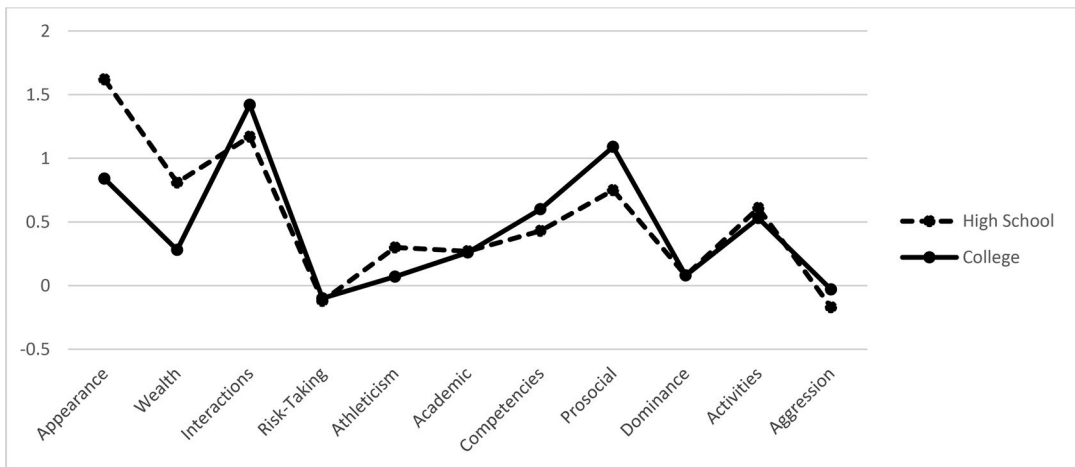


Figure 1. Descriptions of popular high school and college women, integrating frequency and valence. The lines plot the mean of each category for each age group and indicate the valence (positive or negative) of that category. The distance from zero indicates how important that category was for that age group.

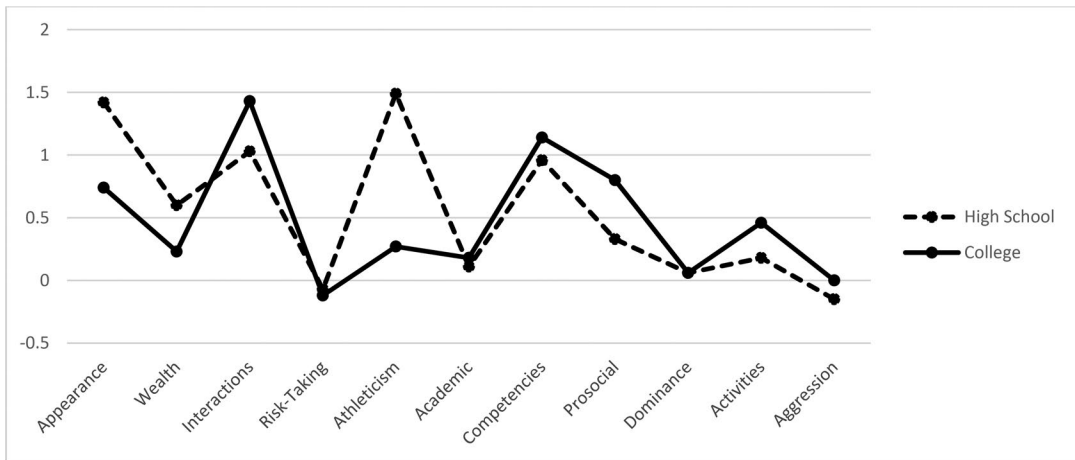


Figure 2. Descriptions of popular high school and college men, integrating frequency and valence. The lines plot the mean of each category for each age group and indicate the valence (positive or negative) of that category. The distance from zero indicates how important that category was for that age group.

positively than popular female peers in terms of their athletic ability and their competencies; popular female peers were rated more positively in terms of their attractiveness, academic ability, prosocial behavior, and school/campus group involvement.

In two cases, the main effect of target gender was qualified by participant gender. This was true for descriptions involving prosocial behavior ($F(1, 215) = 4.12, p = .04$, Wilks' $\lambda = .98$, partial $\eta^2 = .02$). Follow-up tests showed that women described popular female peers in more prosocial terms than they described popular male peers (means = 1.07 and .59 for female and male targets, respectively; $F(1, 216) = 5.85, p = .02$). Men did not differ in their prosocial descriptions of male and female target peers. The target gender $\times$ participant gender interaction was also significant for descriptions involving aggressive behavior, ($F(1, 215) = 4.65, p = .03$, Wilks' $\lambda = .98$, partial $\eta^2 = .02$). Follow-up tests indicated that men described popular male peers as being more aggressive than popular female peers (means = $-.08$ and $-.18$ for female and male targets, respectively; $F(1, 216) = 6.88, p = .009$). Women did not differ in their aggressive descriptions of male and female peers.

Effects of target age

There were significant effects of target age for appearance ($F(1, 215) = 37.19, p = .001$, Wilks' $\lambda = .85$, partial $\eta^2 = .15$), material wealth ($F(1, 215) = 24.55, p = .001$, Wilks' $\lambda = .90$, partial $\eta^2 = .10$), peer interactions ($F(1, 215) = 6.19, p = .01$, Wilks' $\lambda = .97$, partial $\eta^2 = .03$), athletic ability ($F(1, 215) = 119.06, p = .001$, Wilks' $\lambda = .64$, partial $\eta^2 = .36$), prosocial behavior ($F(1, 215) = 5.61, p = .02$, Wilks' $\lambda = .98$, partial $\eta^2 = .03$), and aggressive behavior ($F(1, 215) = 9.31, p = .003$, Wilks' $\lambda = .96$, partial $\eta^2 = .04$). Popular high school students received more positive descriptions than popular college students in terms of their appearance, athletic ability, and wealth. Popular college students were described more favorably in terms of their prosocial behavior and peer interactions. Popular high school peers were described more negatively than popular college peers in regard to their aggressive behavior.

There were significant target gender X target age interactions for descriptions involving athletic ability and school/campus groups. For athletic ability, high school boys received more positive ratings than did high school girls (means = .30 and 1.49 for girls and boys, respectively; $F(1, 217) = 200.06, p = .001$, Wilks' $\lambda = .52$, partial $\eta^2 = .48$), and college men received higher ratings than college women (means = .07 and .27 for women and men, respectively; $F(1, 217) = 9.82, p = .002$, Wilks' $\lambda = .96$, partial $\eta^2 = .04$). High school girls received more positive descriptions for athletic ability than did college women ($F(1, 217) = 12.58, p = .001$, Wilks' $\lambda = .95$, partial $\eta^2 = .06$), while high school boys were described in more positive terms than college men ($F(1, 217) = 178.00, p = .001$, Wilks' $\lambda = .55$, partial $\eta^2 = .45$). For school/campus groups, high school girls were described more positively than high school boys (means = .61 and .18 for girls and boys, respectively; $F(1, 217) = 37.56, p = .001$, Wilks' $\lambda = .85$, partial $\eta^2 = .15$). There were no significant differences in how college men and women were described with regards to school/campus groups involvement. The school/campus groups involvement of college men was described more favorably than that of high school boys (means = .46 and .18 for college men and high school boys, respectively; $F(1, 217) = 13.44, p = .001$, Wilks' $\lambda = .94$, partial $\eta^2 = .06$). There was no significant difference in how high school girls and college women were described.

Discussion

The results of this study indicate that there are indeed differences in how young adults perceive peer popularity in high school versus college. Popular adolescents were described in terms of their appearance, athletic ability, and wealth, consistent with previous findings from studies using similar methods (Closson, 2009; LaFontana & Cillessen, 2002). In descriptions of popular college students, participants focused more on peers' prosocial behavior and peer interactions (such being sociable, outgoing, and likeable). Popular high school students were also described as engaging in aggressive behavior more often than popular college students. These differences suggest changing values as adolescents move into young adulthood, leading to differences in the attributes that garner social prestige. While being attractive, athletic, or wealthy may be crucial for the development of social power in adolescence because they facilitate visibility and prominence (Cillessen & Marks, 2011), these attributes may fade in importance, as popularity becomes more closely tied to positive and meaningful social interactions with others. In college, being sociable and well-integrated with the campus community increases visibility and allows relationships to develop with peers, collaborators, and romantic partners. Furthermore, the fact that the social ecology of the college campus is much larger, and at the same time less cohesive, than that of the high school means that aggression (and particularly relational aggression) may no longer be an effective means of manipulating the peer group to achieve social goals.

In research on peer status in adolescence, the link between popularity and athleticism or sports involvement for boys is robust (Rose et al., 2011). We found a similar pattern, with popular high school boys being described in terms of their athleticism far more often than any

other group, with large effect sizes. Popular high school girls, on the other hand, were almost never described in terms of their athletic ability. In descriptions of college students, men were seen as more athletic than women, but still substantially less so than high school boys. Thus, the power of sports involvement for the development of popularity may be limited to the adolescent years. One explanation for this difference is simply that most high school athletes do not pursue their sport at the college level. Another possibility is that the larger social and cultural context of the college campus means that students have far more options for entertainment, and more opportunities to make connections with peers, than they had at their high school. High school athletes are often ‘big fish in small ponds,’ but at the college level, elite-level athletes may be the only students who can translate sports involvement into social power. While rarely described as athletic, popular high school girls were described as highly involved in other school/campus groups, and much more so than popular high school boys. The activities listed in our participants’ descriptions ranged from cheerleading to student government, suggesting that these activities provide an opportunity for adolescent girls to display leadership, expand their social networks, and achieve the kind of social visibility that sports involvement allows for boys.

The greater focus on competencies for college men, compared to high school boys, is interesting, especially in light of the decreased importance of athleticism. Descriptions of competencies included characteristics like being funny (which was the most common response in this category), having confidence, and being socially skilled. These attributes are consistent with those found in studies of adolescent boys (e.g. Adler et al., 1992; Closson, 2009) as well as college men (Shim & Ryan, 2012), but the limited options for pursuing high-profile sports in college likely allows other skills and talents to be seen as even more valuable in emerging adulthood. High school boys who are funny or talented may be overshadowed by their athletic peers, but college men with these attributes may have the opportunity to stand out more.

Importantly, descriptions of negative behaviors like physical or relational aggression were less commonly used in relation to popular college students, compared to popular high school students (though they were rarely used for high school students, either). Popularity was much more strongly related to prosocial behavior than to aggression in emerging adulthood; in fact, only a handful of participants described popular college peers in aggressive terms. This is somewhat inconsistent with prior studies that have found links between popularity and relational aggression in college students (Lansu & Cillessen, 2012; Shim & Ryan, 2012). These inconsistencies could be due to methodological differences. It is possible that while popular college students are sometimes aggressive, their aggressive behavior is not particularly targeted, frequent, or harmful, making it less salient in an open-ended response task than other more prominent attributes. It may also mean that the social ecology of the college campus is less reinforcing of aggressive behavior compared to the high school, so aggressive popular students making the transition from high school to college find that their behavior is no longer effective at maintaining their peer status, and reduce their aggression (Watling Neal, 2010).

Though we did find significant differences in how popular high school and college students were described in several categories, the overall patterns of descriptions across academic contexts were also similar in important ways. Popular students, regardless of age, were described as attractive and highly engaged with their peers. Though participants described college men significantly more positively in relation to their competencies compared to high school boys, competencies were emphasized for popular males of both ages. Overall, and in the context of the adolescent literature and the few prior studies of popularity in emerging adulthood, this pattern suggests that the foundations of social power in the peer group are similar in adolescence and early adulthood (Lansu & Cillessen, 2012). Attractive individuals who are sociable and well-integrated in the peer network are most likely to be popular.

In addition to differences between high school and college students, we found significant differences across developmental context in how popular male and female peers were described. Consistent with previous research with adolescents (Closson, 2009; Lease et al., 2002; Rodkin

et al., 2000), popular boys were described more frequently in terms of their athletic ability and their competencies (i.e. talents and sense of humor). Popular girls were described in terms of their appearance, prosocial behavior, involvement in school/campus groups, and to a lesser extent, their academic ability. The gender of the perceiver also emerged as an important factor in how popular peers were described. For example, college women described popular female peers as more prosocial than popular male peers, while college men did not make that distinction. This difference could be due to years of socialization pressures on girls and women to focus on interpersonal relationships and to be kind. Women may be more sensitive to others' prosocial behavior than men are. Further, there is evidence that girls have a higher level of interpersonal understanding and better social perception accuracy than boys (Bellmore & Cillessen, 2003; LaFontana & Cillessen, 1999), which may contribute to their greater attunement to prosociality. The opposite pattern was found for descriptions involving aggressive behavior: College men were more likely to attribute aggression to popular male peers than to popular female peers, while college women described popular males and females as equally aggressive. Over the course of adolescence, women may have had more experiences witnessing, and being the victim of, a greater variety of aggressive behaviors by male and female peers, including physical, verbal, and relational forms of aggression. Men, on the other hand, may be more attuned to notice overt forms of aggression like physical harm and verbal bullying, which are more characteristic of males, and less sensitive to relational aggression (Crick, 1995). There is also evidence that adolescent girls judge peers more harshly for being relationally aggressive than adolescent boys do, suggesting that relational aggression may be a more salient attribute of popular peers for female participants (Mayeux, 2011).

The results from this study should be interpreted in light of certain limitations. This study used a cross-sectional design and a combination of retrospective and concurrent reports. The goal in using this approach was to encourage participants to reflect on similarities and differences in popular peers across two developmental contexts. However, it is also possible that this method led to the inflation of the reported differences between popular adolescents and young adults. Participants may have been more likely to focus on the unique or more extreme attributes associated with popularity that differentiated the groups. They may also have been biased toward reporting developmental differences that would be expected, rather than truly observed. For example, participants may have felt compelled to report attributes of popular college peers that reflected a focus on prosocial and relationship-focused behaviors as a means of distinguishing them from the more material and appearance-focused status dynamics that can characterize the high school years. College students may wish to distance themselves from those earlier peer group dynamics, biasing their reporting. Future studies should elicit descriptions of popular peers longitudinally, from high school across the transition into college.

Another limitation is the reliance on retrospective accounts of popular high school peers. Further, we elicited descriptions of popular high school and college peers from primarily first-year college students. Though college campuses tend not to be segregated in terms of age or classification, first-year students may be more likely to interact with each other, rather than older students, given course sequencing (e.g. needing to take introductory-level classes first). Thus, our participants may have provided descriptions that related primarily to younger college students, and may not have captured differences in popularity that emerge across a longer time frame. Given the important goal of understanding what popularity means to adults, eliciting descriptions of popular peers from more advanced college students is also an important avenue for future inquiry. The larger social context of the college campus means it was unlikely that participants knew many of their popular peers well enough to provide deep descriptions of their personalities or other social attributes that might have been relevant to their status. They may have relied on those peers' reputations or highly salient, easily observable attributes like appearance or leadership roles for their descriptions. Their descriptions might also have reflected their experiences within a relatively narrow social circle in the context of the larger campus.

Our open-ended prompt encouraged participants to think about the students in their dorms, apartment complexes, and classes, which may have also served to constrain the social networks that our participants considered when thinking about popular peers. Our sample was also predominantly female, meaning that our findings reflect the perceptions and observations of college women more so than those of college men. Finally, our sample was also predominantly White. While our participants reflected the racial and ethnic composition of the undergraduate population at the university, the small proportions of students from racial and ethnic minority groups made comparisons between groups difficult. Studies of children and adolescents indicate a complex interaction of membership in a particular racial/ethnic group, membership in the minority versus majority group, and the racial/ethnic composition of the peer group (e.g. classroom or grade), in predicting the association between popularity and attributes such as aggression or academic achievement (see Bellmore et al., 2011, for a thoughtful discussion of these issues).

Despite these limitations, the results of this study contribute to our understanding of developmental differences in popularity in adolescence versus emerging adulthood. Our open-ended approach allowed us to identify the attributes associated with popularity that were most salient at two different developmental stages. Young adults who pursue a college education find themselves embedded in a larger social network with a wide variety of social, personal, and academic opportunities to pursue. These significant changes in social ecology are associated with differences in what brings prestige and visibility. Popularity in adolescence is linked to attractiveness, wealth, and high-profile talents such as athleticism—attributes that promote social visibility in the peer group. Popularity in emerging adulthood is more closely associated with high levels of peer interaction and sociability, involvement in campus groups, and prosocial behavior—attributes that promote visibility but also foster deeper personal relationships and connections that might facilitate success in friendships, romantic relationships, and academic and career opportunities. Overall, the differences that emerged in our participants' descriptions reflect a greater focus on positive behavioral attributes and less focus on aggression and extrinsic successes, suggesting that adult conceptualizations of social power may shift in the direction of emphasizing kindness, talents, and other social competencies. This is a significant change from the mixed profile of prosocial and antisocial behavior that is associated with popularity in adolescence (Cillessen et al., 2011), and suggests potentially fruitful avenues for further inquiry regarding young adults' evolving social goals and values. From a practical standpoint, our findings may give encouragement to parents and to adolescents who are sociable and kind, but who are overlooked in their schools in favor of peers who hold more attention-getting power via attractiveness, wealth, and athleticism. Our findings suggest that those prosocial, outgoing high school students reap social rewards on the college campus. Longitudinal research addressing adolescents' transition into emerging adults, particularly in the context of the college setting and beyond, will yield important insight into the changing nature of popularity.

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Data availability statement

The data that support the findings of this study are available from the corresponding author, LM, upon reasonable request.

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Appendix

Content codes used to categorize descriptions of popular peers

1. Physical appearance
 - a. Attractiveness ('good-looking')
 - a. Hygiene ('poor hygiene')
 - b. Stature or physical maturity ('looks older than they are')
2. Material wealth
 - a. Money/financial security or status ('lower economic status')
 - b. Possessions ('wore the latest designer clothing')
3. Peer interactions
 - a. Liking ('well-liked')
 - b. High frequency of interaction/sociable/extraverted ('outgoing')
 - c. Low frequency of interaction/withdrawn ('timid')
 - d. 'partying' ('had the best parties')
 - e. opposite-sex interactions ('had many boyfriends')
 - f. popularity ('hung around the popular crowd')
4. Risk-taking behavior
 - a. Drinking ('drank a lot')
 - b. Other substance use ('smoked weed')
5. Athletic Ability ('good at sports')
6. Academic Performance ('nerds')
7. Intelligence ('smart')
8. Competencies/Incompetencies
 - a. Talents ('play instruments,' 'good at cooking')
 - b. sense of humor ('funny')
 - c. socially appropriate or inappropriate behavior ('obnoxious')
 - d. confidence ('aren't afraid to speak their minds')
9. (Non)conformity
 - a. Act different from others, stand out for negative reasons ('doesn't care what others think')
 - b. Act the same as others, try to conform ('tried hard to be like the popular kids')
10. Prosocial behavior ('nice to everyone')

11. Dominance
 - a. recognition, visibility ('everyone knew who they were')
 - b. power or manipulation ('intimidating;' 'others wanted to be like them')
12. School/Campus Groups ('involved in lots of clubs' for high school students; 'in a sorority' for college students)
13. Motivation to Attain Status ('wanted to be high-profile')
14. Aggressive Behavior
 - a. Physical aggression ('got into a lot of fights')
 - b. Relational aggression ('talked bad about other people')
15. Behavioral – not specified (last resort)
16. Personality – not specified (last resort)